

Ἀδέσποτα Παπυράκεα Ἑξάμετρα

Hexameter Papyri Anonymous on Elegies and Epigrams

eul_aid: jni

Period: Ἑλληνιστική [Hellenistic](#)
Dialect: Ἑπική [Epic \(Homeric\)](#) (frg)
Domain: Ποίησις [Poetry](#)
Format: Ἑμμετρος [Verse](#)

Hexameter Papyri Anonymous is a modern designation for a vast corpus of anonymous Greek hexameter poetry preserved on papyrus fragments, not a single author. The fragments date from the 3rd century BCE to the 7th century CE, spanning the Hellenistic to early Byzantine periods, primarily from Egypt. No biographical details exist for the countless unknown poets represented; their social and geographical origins are lost.

The corpus includes thousands of fragmentary texts in the Homeric dialect. Major categories are Homeric papyri of the Iliad and Odyssey, fragments of the Homeric Hymns and Hesiodic works, and Orphic literature. It also encompasses hexameter oracles, didactic poetry, and entirely new, unknown compositions termed *adespota*. Most fragments are brief, often just a few damaged lines.

These papyri are crucial for understanding ancient Greek literary culture beyond the canon. They demonstrate the enduring influence of Homeric meter and dialect, provide older textual variants for major authors, and reveal a diverse, largely lost landscape of popular, religious, and local verse. They are essential evidence for poetic activity, textual transmission, and educational practices over a millennium.

Works (4)

- Ἑλεγείαι · [Elegies](#) · 57 passages
- Ἑπιγράμματα · [Epigrams](#) · 104 passages
- Ἑξάμετροι · [Hexameters](#) · 218 passages
- Μικτὰ · [Miscellanea](#) · 45 passages